

Philosophy of Mind: A Building Block

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Armstrong's type identity states that every mental state is identical to some brain state types and by extension, the mind just is the brain. This thesis is a response and possible solution to the mind-body problem originally posited by Descartes. It's overall an improvement of the behaviorists' position because it claims that mental states and events are just inner causes of behavior, which means that the brain is doing it, and not the body's response to its environment. He does so by distinguishing the difference between intentional mental states and conscious mental states in order to equate the mental and brain state. In doing so though, he fails to account for secondary qualities and its harm to his thesis. Therefore, type identity, while a good argument, does not fully address or solve the mind body problem.

First, Armstrong's thesis is a response to Descartes' substance dualism, which is that mind and body are distinct separate beings. Behaviorists disagree, and their response and reasoning are that the mind and body are just one being because mental states are just consequences of a person's environment. This behaviorist's theory was not widely loved as a philosophical argument, but Armstrong's type identity no doubt is an improvement of it. Type identity is an improvement because it distinguishes the difference between two mental state types. Therefore, in doing so, it supposedly solves the problem of how the mind and body causally interact.

Furthermore, in order to understand Armstrong's thesis, we must first learn the two types of identity. The first type is used as an equality function between two things. For

instance, if we say *the morning star* = *the night star*, then we are saying that $a = b$ which means both a and b are referring to the same thing. The second type is used when predicating a condition, property, or feature on to something. For example, if we say the sky is blue, then we are saying the color blue is a feature, property, or condition of the sky. Armstrong will use the first type of identity to equate the mind and brain such that they are referencing or referring to the same thing.

Now, we must define what a type even is. The best way to illustrate this is to compare it to a token. Let's say we have a set of $\{Q, Q, Q, Q\}$, how many Q 's do we have? If we are referring to a token, we would say four because there are four instances of the letter Q . But, if we are talking about a type, then we would say one because even if there are four instances, there is only one type of the same letter. Since we have defined type, we can now apply this illustration to mental types.

We have now arrived at types of mental states. Armstrong argues for two different mental state types. The first mental state is intentional or representational, and it is a mental state which represents the world as being a certain or desired way. This includes different distinct psychological kinds like fears, desires, perceptions, and these kinds have representational contents. Representational contents can also be distinct like in the case of $2 + 2 = 4$ or that it is raining. To illustrate, if I say I believe pigs fly, then my intentional mental state is representing the world as being a certain way, and that way is that pigs fly. My psychological kind is belief, and my representational content is pigs flying.

The second mental state is a conscious mental state, which are things like feelings. Conscious mental states may be about something, but it is always about the experience of an agent's state. An easier way to put this is when you are talking about an experience and the phrase "it's like" is used. For example, if I am explaining the feeling of how my thought operates and I say it's like building ideas out of Lego pieces, but for the mind, then I am talking about my experience in the state of thought as the agent. Therefore, I am describing my subjective conscious mind. The subjective conscious mind can also have subcategories of experience like touch, tickling, different types of pain, but they are all just different ways of explaining my feelings in an experience.

Secondly, Armstrong's purpose in differentiating between types, tokens, and states is to give us the necessary tools to analyze how mental concepts are states of the brain. He encounters several obstacles in doing so though. One obstacle he faces is that the feeling of things like pain are not linguistically identical to certain neuron fibers being activated. For instance, if I drop a weight on my foot, I cannot say that my (placeholder values) *a*, *b*, and *c* fibers are being used. Therefore, it seems unlikely that activated neurons are the same as thing as feelings, sensations, and pains.

Moreover, his solution to this is that the concept of a mental state type "is the concept of a state that is apt to be the cause of certain effects or apt to be the effect of certain causes" (Armstrong 33). Meaning, that when we say 'pain' we are referring to an experience with quintessential causes like cell damage and quintessential effects like screaming. Therefore,

the casual relationship between mind and brain is the external causes which cause certain bodily effects in the brain. For instance, when it rains and my mind experiences it, it's because the external cause of rain falling on me changes my brain state which changes my mental state.

Lastly, if this is the solution, then it raises the objection of secondary qualities. First, a secondary quality according to Locke is a characteristic of a physical object which produces certain kinds of experiences for humans (Locke). These secondary qualities return a sensation which is different from the physical representations we experience. For example, if we posit the question: 'what is blueness?', then we can say two things. Blue is reflection or wavelength of color in the physical world which representations the mental intentional state, but now, what is a blue sensation? The answer given is that it is a type of brain state. If it's a type of brain state, which brain state? A brain state that is caused by blue sensation. Well, what is a blue sensation? From this we can see, that Armstrong is caught in a circular argument regarding secondary qualities and therefore does not solve the substance dualism problem.

Overall, Armstrong's thesis of type theory does improve on behavioralism because it explains how mental states and events are internally caused from behavior, and the answer is the brain. It also improves on dualism by providing a solution that includes the mental cause of bodily events without including any undefined terms or entities. Alas, his theory still falls short to circular reasoning for secondary qualities. Therefore, Armstrong's type theory may not be enough to counter substance dualism, but it's a great building block.

Works Cited

Armstrong, David M. "Armstrong's causal theory of mind." *DM Armstrong*. Springer, 1984. 79–120. Print.

Locke, John. *An essay concerning human understanding*. Kay & Troutman, 1847. Print.